같은 뜻, 다른 느낌: 칭찬일까, 흉일까?

Learn five pairs of Korean words that mean almost the same thing but feel different: one sounds kind or polite, and the other sounds blunt or negative.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

By the end, you can read a short review, comment or conversation and tell whether a word sounds positive, negative, polite or casual. You can also choose the right word from five common pairs.

1 FIVE PAIRS: SAME MEANING, DIFFERENT FEELING

1. **날씬하다** (slim)
   A compliment about a nice body shape.
   예: 언니는 키가 크고 날씬해요.
2. **마르다** (thin, skinny)
   Often sounds like worry: too thin, maybe not eating well.
   예: 요즘 많이 말랐네. 밥은 잘 먹어?
3. **저렴하다** (inexpensive, affordable)
   A polite word for low prices, common in writing, ads and reviews.
   예: 이 식당은 점심 메뉴가 저렴한 편이에요.
4. **싸다** (cheap)
   A casual word; sometimes it suggests low quality.
   예: 시장에서 사면 훨씬 싸요.
5. **향기** (pleasant scent)
   Used only for good smells, like flowers, soap or perfume.
   예: 이 비누는 향기가 좋아요.
6. **냄새** (smell)
   A neutral word; with words like 이상한 or 탄, it means a bad smell.
   예: 부엌에서 탄 냄새가 나요.
7. **아끼다** (to save, to use carefully)
   A good habit of not wasting. 아끼지 않다 means 'to be generous'.
   예: 물을 아껴 써야 해요.
8. **짜다** (stingy)
   A casual, negative word for a person who does not like to spend or share.
   예: 우리 사장님은 너무 짜요. 커피 한 잔도 안 사 줘요.
9. **나이가 들다** (to get older)
   A soft, respectful way to talk about age.
   예: 나이가 들면서 성격이 부드러워졌어요.
10. **늙다** (to get old)
    Blunt; it can hurt when you say it about someone else.
    예: 늙었다는 말을 들으면 기분이 안 좋아요.

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2 READ: A CAFÉ REVIEW

회사 근처에 있는 작은 카페예요. 커피 값이 저렴하고, 문을 열고 들어가면 커피 향기가 좋아요. 사장님이 재료를 아끼지 않아서 케이크도 크고 맛있어요. 다만 손님이 많아서 좀 시끄러워요.

The writer likes this café. The words 저렴하다, 향기 and 아끼지 않다 all sound positive. Only the last sentence is a complaint.

3 TIP: HOW TO CHOOSE

Before you choose a word, ask yourself two questions. Am I praising, or am I worried or complaining? Am I writing something polite (an ad, a review, a message to a boss), or chatting with a friend?
Koreans, especially older family members, often talk about weight when they meet you. '많이 말랐네' is usually worry, not a compliment, so don't take it as one. And don't say 늙었어요 about other people. Even as a joke, it can sound rude.

The words come in pairs. The first word in each pair usually sounds softer, more polite or more positive.

4 YOUR TURN

CHOOSE THE RIGHT FEELING

Think about each situation: are you praising or worrying? Is it polite writing or a casual chat? Then choose or write the word that fits.

1. Choose the word that fits:
①쓰레기통에서 이상한 (향기 / 냄새)가 나요.
②친구가 너무 (아껴서 / 짜서) 같이 밥 먹기가 싫어요.

2. Your friend lost a lot of weight because she was sick. Which word shows that you are worried about her? 너 많이 (날씬해졌네 / 말랐네). 괜찮아?

3. You are writing an ad for a hotel website. Which word sounds more polite? 저희 호텔은 객실 요금이 (저렴합니다 / 쌉니다).

4. Read and answer in English. Is 민수 씨 stingy? Why or why not?:
민수 씨는 평소에 돈을 아껴 써요. 그런데 친구 생일 선물에는 돈을 아끼지 않아요.

5. Rewrite the sentence so it sounds softer. Use 나이가 들다:
저도 이제 늙어서 밤에 잠을 잘 못 자요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① 냄새 ② 짜서
2) 말랐네
3) 저렴합니다
4) No. He saves money in daily life, but he is generous when he buys his friends' birthday gifts.
5) 저도 이제 나이가 들어서 밤에 잠을 잘 못 자요.

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